ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Academic Writing and Referencing: Say It Clearly, Cite It Properly

Structure, argument and citations for assignments that would otherwise lose marks

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Marks are lost for the same reasons every semester: no clear argument, weak structure, quotation without citation and padding. This pack covers essay structure, paragraph logic, APA-style citation, paraphrasing and proofreading.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Plan and structure an academic essay with a clear thesis.
- Write paragraphs that make one point and support it with evidence.
- Cite sources correctly in APA style and paraphrase without plagiarising.
- Proofread for clarity, grammar and consistency.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Structure before style

An academic assignment answers a question with a reasoned argument.

- Introduction: context, the question, your thesis and the route of the essay.
- Body: one point per paragraph, each supported by evidence and explanation.
- Conclusion: restate the answer, not new arguments.
- Use headings when the assignment is long and permits them.
- Define key terms early, especially contested ones.
- Aim for clarity over impressive vocabulary.

> **The thesis test**
> Read your introduction alone. Can a stranger state your position? If not, your thesis is not yet doing its job.

Citation and plagiarism

Referencing is not decoration; it lets a reader verify your evidence and distinguishes your ideas from others'.

- In-text citation, APA style: (Author, Year) or Author (Year).
- Reference list entries: author, year, title, source and access details where required.
- Cite page numbers for direct quotations.
- Paraphrase by understanding, closing the source and writing in your own structure.
- Copying without citation is plagiarism, whether or not you intended it.
- Keep a working reference list while writing, not after.

Editing and proofreading

Editing is where average drafts become good assignments.

1. Put the draft aside for a few hours before editing.
2. Check that every paragraph has one clear point.
3. Read aloud to catch awkward or run-on sentences.
4. Verify every citation and reference entry.
5. Check formatting, font, spacing and word count.
6. Get one reader to explain your argument back to you.

> **Common killers**
> No clear thesis, unsupported claims, long quotations doing the thinking, and references that do not match in-text citations.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the function of a thesis statement?

Answer: It states the central claim the essay will defend, giving the reader a clear position to follow.

2. How do you paraphrase without plagiarising?

Answer: Understand the passage, close the source, rewrite the idea in your own words and structure, then cite the source.

3. Write an APA in-text citation for a 2021 book by Ada Obi.

Answer: (Obi, 2021) or Obi (2021) if used as part of the sentence.

4. Why is a long quotation a weakness unless analysed?

Answer: It replaces your reasoning with someone else's words; marks are earned by analysing the evidence.

5. Name three proofreading checks.

Answer: Paragraph focus, sentence clarity and citation accuracy. Formatting and word count also count.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write a thesis statement for one assignment question.
- [ ] Outline three body paragraphs with evidence for each.
- [ ] Draft a 500-word essay and self-edit it twice.
- [ ] Build a reference list in APA style with five sources.
- [ ] Practise paraphrasing one paragraph and compare with the original.
- [ ] Read your draft aloud and mark every sentence that stumbles.
- [ ] Ask a coursemate to summarise your argument from the draft.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: